Appendix D | Written solutions

Complexity and Memory Accounting

Count arithmetic, live tensor payload, reserved capacity, and elapsed time separately. The worked examples show exactly which dimensions enter each estimate and why a smaller cache does not imply an identical speed improvement.

Eight exercises progress from tracing small calculations to diagnosing implementation errors. These are controlled numerical examples, not performance or model-quality benchmarks.

1. Count permitted work

Problem. For six causal tokens, window width three including the current token, two query heads, and key/value widths four each, count permitted pairs and the MACs for the two attention products when excluded pairs are skipped.

Solution. Each query reads $\min(t, 3)$ keys, giving counts $(1, 2, 3, 3, 3, 3)$ and 15 pairs per head. Each pair costs four MACs for its query/key dot product and four for its weighted value contribution. With two heads, the total is $2(15)(4 + 4) = 240$ MACs, or 480 FLOPs under the convention of two FLOPs per MAC. Scaling, softmax, projections, and other operations are excluded. A dense implementation that computes masked entries as well does more arithmetic.

2. Track trainable arrays

Problem. A model stores two million FP32 weights, with only 50,000 trainable. Count all weights plus FP32 gradients and two Adam moments for the trainable subset. Name another allocation to measure.

Solution. The weights occupy $2{,}000{,}000(4) = 8{,}000{,}000$ bytes. Gradients occupy $50{,}000(4) = 200{,}000$ bytes, and two moments occupy 400,000 bytes. The total is 8,600,000 bytes, or 8.6 decimal MB. This assumes no additional master weight copy and no gradient or moment arrays for frozen weights. Saved activations and temporary workspaces can add substantially to the peak; freezing parameters does not automatically eliminate all activations needed to differentiate through a frozen computation.

3. Convert hybrid history to bytes

Problem. Two attention layers each have one KV head with key/value widths eight. One recurrent layer stores 32 scalars per sequence. Batch size is two and every scalar uses two bytes. Count history for lengths 16 and 32.

Solution. The attention contribution is 2 examples $\times$ 2 layers $\times$ n $\times$ 1 head $\times$ $(8 + 8) \times 2 = 128n$ bytes. The recurrent state contributes $2(32)(2) = 128$ bytes. Thus $M(n) = 128n + 128$, giving 2,176 bytes at 16 and 4,224 at 32. Only the attention history grows. These assumptions differ from Exercise 6, where the batch is one and the recurrent state is FP32.

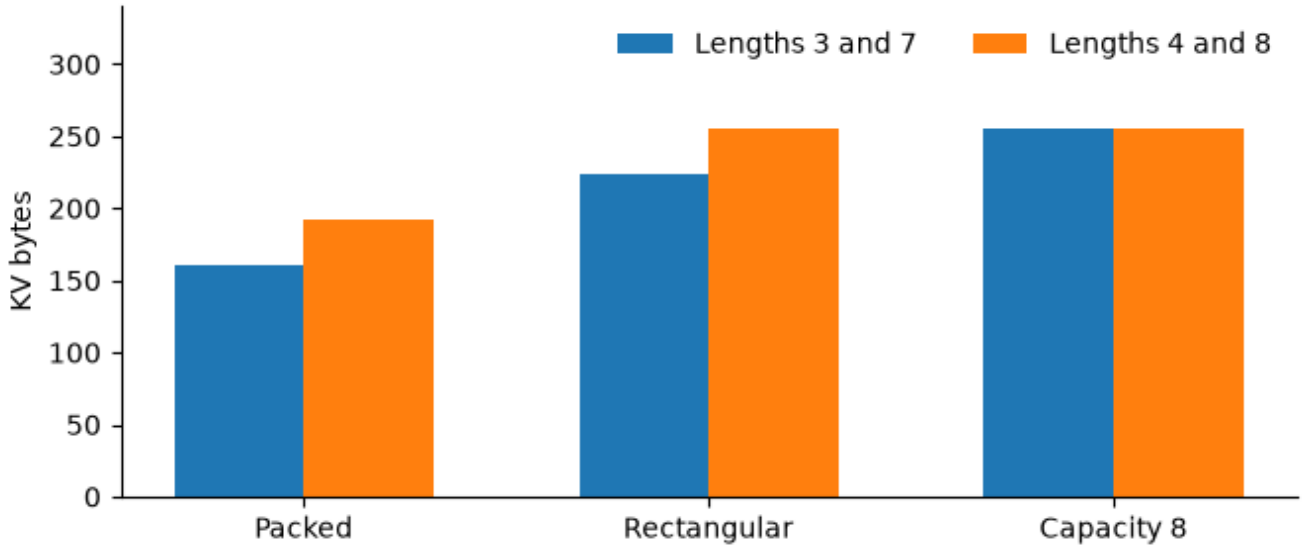
4. Define a fair timing run

Problem. Two models generate equally long responses to the same prompt. Define separate prompt and decode timers, controlled settings, and throughput numerators.

Solution. For a model-only prompt measurement, place synchronized device timing boundaries around the forward call that consumes the full prompt and produces the first-token logits. State that tokenization, queueing, transfer, and sampling are excluded if they are outside the timer. For decode, start after the first emitted token and stop after the final emitted token, counting only the subsequent output tokens. End-to-end timing instead starts at the declared request boundary and counts all output tokens through the final emission. Hold device, batch, prompt length, requested output length, dtype, sampling policy, and relevant execution settings fixed. Warm up the tested path, measure repeated runs, and report variability. Equal nominal dtype does not make architecture or output quality equal. The code below checks a timing-accounting fixture; it is not a hardware benchmark.

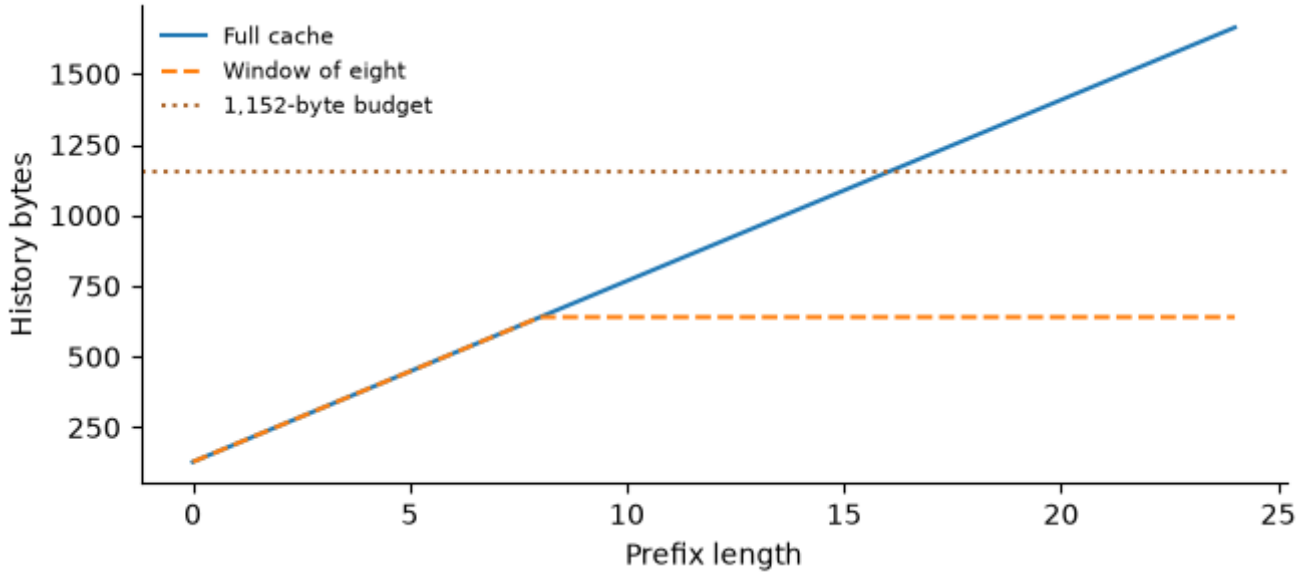
5. Count occupied and reserved slots

Problem. Lengths are 3 and 7. One layer and one KV head use key/value widths four and two-byte scalars. Count packed payload, rectangular allocation, and capacity eight per sequence. Then add one token to each sequence.
Solution. Each retained position occupies $(4+4)(2) = 16$ bytes. Initially, packed storage uses $(3+7)(16) = 160$ bytes, a rectangle uses $2(7)(16) = 224$, and fixed capacity uses $2(8)(16) = 256$. For lengths 4 and 8, packed storage grows to 192 and the rectangle to 256; capacity-eight storage stays at 256 because its slots were already reserved. The occupied bytes still increase. Page granularity, metadata, temporary growth copies, and allocator overhead are excluded.



6. Solve a history budget

Problem. One sequence has two attention layers with one KV head, key/value widths eight and two-byte scalars, plus 32 FP32 recurrent scalars. Find the largest full-cache prefix under 1,152 bytes and the plateau with a window of eight.
Solution. Each position across the two attention layers costs $2(8+8)(2) = 64$ bytes. The recurrent state needs $32(4) = 128$ bytes. Solve $64n + 128 \leq 1152$, giving $n \leq 16$. At 16 the payload is exactly 1,152; at 17 it is 1,216 and no longer fits. With actual eviction to a window of eight, the history is $64\min(n, 8) + 128$, which plateaus at 640 bytes. This budget covers history only, not weights, workspaces, or allocator overhead.



7. Count live overlap

Problem. Persistent arrays use 8 MiB, saved activations 3, a forward workspace 5, and a backward workspace 4. The four phases are forward workspace live, forward workspace freed, backward workspace live, and saved tensors freed. Reproduce totals and add a 2 MiB copy through phases 1-3. What if it is a view?

Solution. The totals are $8 + 3 + 5 = 16$, $8 + 3 = 11$, $8 + 3 + 4 = 15$, and 8 MiB. Peak payload is 16 MiB; summing all allocations would incorrectly give 20 because the workspaces do not coexist. A real 2 MiB copy in the first three phases gives totals $(18, 13, 17, 8)$ and peak 18. A view sharing existing storage adds no second 2 MiB payload, so the tensor-payload peak stays 16. Small view metadata and allocator reservations belong to separate accounting.

8. Audit a throughput claim

Problem. Four concurrent requests start at 0 and each emit tokens at 90, 115, 140, and 165 ms. Find TTFT, inter-token latency, aggregate decode throughput, and aggregate complete-request output throughput. Audit $16/0.075$ and a claim that halving KV bytes halves time.

Solution. Each request has TTFT 90 ms and subsequent intervals 25 ms. After the first emission, the batch generates $4(3) = 12$ tokens in 75 ms, giving 160 tokens/s. Across the complete interval, it generates $4(4) = 16$ in 165 ms, giving about 96.97 tokens/s. The claim $16/0.075 \approx 213.33$ includes the first tokens in its numerator while excluding their elapsed time. A single request has 40 tokens/s steady cadence here, which is distinct from batch throughput. KV payload does not determine total latency: projections, attention reads, scheduling, communication, and other work must also be measured.